

Tabloid TECH

People And Events That Grabbed The Headlines—For Better Or For Worse

Out In The Open

Couples break up all the time. Some use letters, some do so by phone while others use SMS. But Jimmy Wales didn't use any of these ordinary methods. Rather, in the interests of transparency he decided to dump his girlfriend by announcing it first on Wikipedia!

Wales, who styles himself the "benevolent dictator" and "spiritual leader" of Wikipedia, the free encyclopaedia that anyone can edit has decided to sever all ties with Rachel Marsden, a conservative journalist. This was the ending of a pretty knotty relationship, whose aftermath caused a lot of raised eyebrows all over the blogosphere.

Rachel Marsden was a Canadian media personality who didn't like her biography on Wikipedia. It apparently harped too much on some unpleasant incidents of her past life which she didn't want people to know. Being a go-getter she went for the source, petitioning the benevolent dictator to correct the "mistakes". Wales put in a suggestion to his editing team and they carried out his orders. This led to quite a few dates and everything seemed hunky dory. However, something—which we will never know—came between the two lovebirds, and this led to a pretty ugly spat, with the lady leaking their salacious chat records to a gossip blog. The lady seems so determined to remove any association with Wales that she put his clothes—which he had left behind in her apartment—up for sale on eBay.

While the entries about their plans for the night might make interesting reading what's troubling to many is how Wikipedia has been used for furthering the interests of a person, or a circle. For instance, Wales attempted to bill \$650 (about

Rs 27,000) for two bottles of wine as expenses to the Wikimedia foundation. That money is actually coming from the donations for more server space and more features. There are many other indiscretions which are probably okay if an office worker had committed them, but definitely not okay when you are virtually in charge of one of the most visited Web sites on the Internet. Somebody should tell him to grow up. Oh, and in case you didn't get it, take everything on Wikipedia with a pinch of salt.

Internet-bashing

Everyone agrees that despite the many shortcomings of the Internet, there are plenty of things which you can do online. Among the things that are counted as good is e-voting where you needn't queue up in a polling booth to exercise your democratic rights. You get the vote even if it's raining, democracy wins and every one is happy.

Except for a former Polish prime minister. Jaroslaw Kaczynski apparently thinks that the Internet is Satan's workshop and people should not be allowed to vote online. In fact he seemed to be worried about the youth population and felt that predominance of porn, along with beer would cloud their judgement and they would mistakenly hit the wrong button. He thinks that manipulating people online is easier than, say, in a public meeting where you run the risk of getting rotten things thrown at your face.

Ironically these remarks were published not in a newspaper or reported in a TV show



but in a Web page. Besides it's not that Kaczynski, is a technophobe. In December he had set up a video blog so that he could connect with people. So what could be made of the latest bout of Internet bashing? Maybe, like other politicians, he is just playing to the gallery, which in this case consists of a cult which has sworn off the Internet and whose votes he is coveting. Crazier things have happened in politics.

Blogophobia: Off the Mark



Mark Cuban is a man who is the owner of an online media company and also the owner of a basketball team. He is pretty Net savvy and he knows what a blog is. So eye-

brows were raised when he banned all blogs from publishing inside scoops from the locker room in response to blistering comments about the performance of his team in a blog. Which means that no more tidbits and first hand information: everything had to be picked off from the traditional media.

After getting plastered all over the Internet for a decision that at best can be described as childish, Cuban decided that he hadn't done enough to prevent the spread of misinformation by new age media. In a next salvo he pontificated that newspapers should stop calling their blogs as blogs. He seems to think that blogs are associated with hasty and inaccurate reporting and newspapers ought to know better than to encourage this brand of journalism. In fact he sees a branding opportunity and says that blogging should be renamed as Real Time Reporting, probably because he assumes all blogs are hurriedly written without the cross checking of facts which traditional newspaper reporters do. While many blogs out there are lousy and slapdash there are an equal number of newspaper articles which are written minutes before going to press. We only assume that Cuban did not have the grace enough to admit he was wrong the first time and tried to play with words and semantics to fool people.

Sorry Mark, you just have to admit you are wrong and stop being obnoxious. Is it that hard?